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Generative AI as a Gatekeeper: Uncovering Affordance-Based Gatekeeping Mechanisms in Media Ecosystems

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ABSTRACT

Gatekeeping in the media industry has historically been exercised primarily by publishers and editorial actors but increasingly shifted toward platform companies and their algorithmic infrastructures with the rise of digital platforms. The affordances of generative artificial intelligence (GenAI), however, introduce new points of control across the full media value chain, challenging this assumption. This paper examines how GenAI reshapes gatekeeping across the media value chain through a qualitative multiple-case study of seven European publishers based on a data collection in 2024. Our analysis identifies five GenAI-induced, affordance-driven gatekeeping mechanisms spanning along the media value chain. Collectively, these mechanisms produce a redistribution of power among publishers, AI providers, and audiences, in which publishers cede control upstream to infrastructure providers and downstream to users. We argue that GenAI constitutes a systemic structuring force that redefines not only where gatekeeping occurs, but also how media work is organized around provision, generation, and interaction. In doing so, it fundamentally alters how value is created and captured across the media value chain.

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Introduction

Gatekeeping, understood as the selective structuring of information flows, shapes how knowledge circulates in society (Shoemaker & Vos, 2014). With the rise of generative artificial intelligence (GenAI), gatekeeping is undergoing another profound shift, as AI systems not only filter and distribute but also generate and transform media content. This matters because GenAI directly intervenes in the ways content is created, circulated, and received (Banh & Strobel, 2023), thereby reshaping the conditions under which media organizations operate. At the same time, gatekeeping has never been static. Earlier disruptions, brought about by the internet and platforms, reshaped circulation and visibility (Cornière & Sarvary, 2023;

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Ren et al., 2024). They turned digital intermediaries into powerful actors that surface, rank, and filter news (Nielsen & Ganter, 2018). In this sense, GenAI extends an ongoing trajectory of change, yet pushes it further by intervening not only at the level of distribution but also at the very stages of content creation and reception.

GenAI is widely seen as a disruptive technology with consequences that go well beyond efficiency gains (Benbya et al., 2024). Media organizations everywhere are now assessing if, where, and to what extent it should be used in editorial or commercial processes (Chan-Olmsted, 2019). These assessments are not only about speed or cost savings, but also about broader effects that may not be immediately visible, for example, on editorial authority, audience relationships, or the role of journalism in society (Simon, 2024). For an industry built around the creation and distribution of content, GenAI therefore represents both an opportunity and a challenge, pushing media companies to reconsider how they work and on what terms.

Dependencies in media ecosystems have long been analyzed, especially in the context of digital platforms (Nieborg & Poell, 2018; Nielsen & Ganter, 2018). Recent discussions on GenAI, by contrast, have often approached the technology from an innovation or efficiency perspective, for instance, highlighting newsroom automation (Diakopoulos, 2019) or user perceptions (Rix et al., 2025). What we have not yet understood is how GenAI reshapes gatekeeping in traditional media organizations, which do not develop large-scale models themselves but must navigate new dependencies on external infrastructures and changing relationships with audiences. Therefore, we ask:

How does GenAI reshape gatekeeping across the media value chain?

This paper examines how GenAI reshapes media gatekeeping by transforming both content creation workflows and user-oriented media experiences. Drawing on a qualitative study of media organizations and explicitly adopting a publisher-centric perspective, we uncover how GenAI introduces new mechanisms that alter content production, circulation, and reception and constrain publishers' control over these processes. We introduce five gatekeeping mechanisms—infrastructural, editorial, recomposition, conversational, and personalization gatekeeping—and argue that GenAI creates additional gates, extending the role of intermediaries further upstream into content creation and downstream into reception in the media value chain. Building on these insights, this study advances the literature in three ways. First, it demonstrates the emergence of additional gates driven by GenAI's affordances. Second, it elaborates on shifting power distributions in the media ecosystem, where AI providers and users gain influence while publishers face a “loss-loss” dynamic of diminished control. Third, it adds to the literature on power asymmetries in media ecosystems.

Theoretical and technical background

This section lays the groundwork for our analysis by combining two perspectives: the theoretical lens of gatekeeping theory, and the technical foundations of GenAI and its affordances along the media value chain. Together, these elements provide the basis for examining how GenAI reconfigures information flows.

Gatekeeping theory and gatekeeping mechanisms on digital platforms

Gatekeeping theory provides a lens for understanding how information is controlled, prioritized, and distributed in mediated environments. The theory examines how gatekeepers, as actors or institutions, actively decide which information to include, exclude, emphasize, or modify as it passes through specific gates (Shoemaker & Vos, 2009). These decisions, far from being passive, represent deliberate acts of facilitation or constraint that shape the flow of information (Shoemaker & Reese, 2014). Rooted in communication and journalism studies, the concept has been widely applied across media and related disciplines to analyze how editorial, organizational, and technological practices shape information flows (Barzilai-Nahon, 2008).

Central to the theory are several constructs that clarify how gatekeeping operates. *Gatekeepers* regulate the flow of information, traditionally encompassing media organizations, publishers, and editors. In the digital age, algorithms and platforms increasingly fulfill this role (Napoli, 2015; Wallace, 2018). *Gates* serve as the points of control, such as editorial reviews or algorithmic systems that rank search results. *Mechanisms* like filtering, ranking, and timing embody gatekeepers' methods to enact control, shaping which information is selected, withheld, or modified (Bro & Wallberg, 2014). On the other hand, *the gated* are those subject to gatekeeping processes, including content creators and publishers, whose access to audiences depends on the decisions of gatekeepers (Russell, 2019). In this study, we take the perspective of the traditional media companies as the gated., while recognizing that gatekeeping is conceptualized as a relational and position-dependent phenomenon, allowing actors to occupy both roles simultaneously (Barzilai-Nahon, 2008). While publishers historically exercised gatekeeping authority over journalistic content, they are increasingly subject to infrastructural and algorithmic gatekeeping by platforms and GenAI systems that structure access to audiences. Accordingly, our analysis foregrounds media companies as gated actors in relation to these systems, while acknowledging their continued gatekeeping role at other points in the media value chain.

Figure 1 illustrates how traditional media companies are gatekept (before the advent of GenAI). The flow of content (Ci) starts with content creation by traditional media companies. Digital platforms gate them during

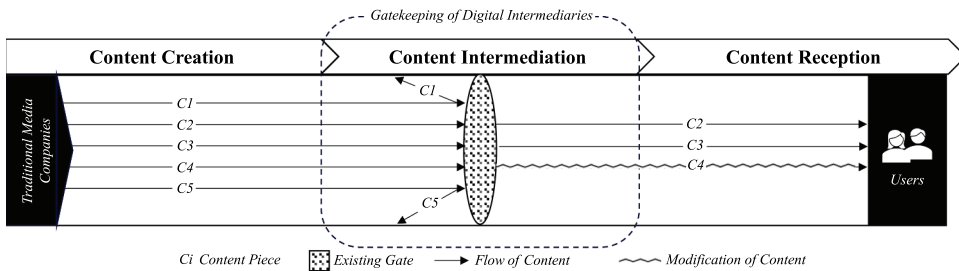


Figure 1. Gatekeeping prior to GenAI.

intermediation (via ranking, selection, or personalization). Their gate only lets certain content pass (C2 and C3) and modifies others (C4) before it reaches users. Moreover, digital platforms hold control over access to infrastructure, data, and audiences (Bro & Wallberg, 2014; Russell, 2019).

This section focuses on concrete gatekeeping mechanisms enacted by digital platforms, where gatekeeping has been concentrated at the intermediation stage of the media value chain (Anter, 2024). As platforms have assumed dominant control over distribution, visibility, and audience access, publishers themselves increasingly become the “gated” actors within the ecosystem. Algorithmic curation refers to the filtering and ranking of content based on engagement metrics, personalization data, or commercial incentives (Wallace, 2018). In response, publishers increasingly adapt their content to align with algorithmic preferences: optimizing headlines, formats, and publishing times to improve visibility and ranking. Thus, algorithmic curation not only shapes what content audiences see but also retroactively influences how content is produced in the first place. Network control involves platforms’ decisions over what infrastructure and distribution channels are made available to which actors, reinforcing structural power over visibility (Barzilai-Nahon, 2008; Gillespie, 2020). Content moderation includes platform-driven efforts to remove, flag, or deprioritize problematic content, often in response to legal, ethical, or reputational pressures (Hermida, 2020). Finally, while user interaction also influences visibility through likes, shares, or follows, we frame it here as a platform-enabled mechanism, one that remains dependent on system design and affordances (Singer, 2014).

The role of AI in shaping information flows has increasingly attracted scholarly attention. Prior research shows that algorithmic systems filter, rank, and curate content, thereby shaping visibility and audience access in ways that differ fundamentally from human editorial practice (Russell, 2019; Van Dalen, 2023; Voinea, 2025). At the same time, newsrooms adapt to these infrastructures, leading to an increasing entanglement of professional practices with algorithmic logics (Cornia et al., 2020). Yet this body of work remains largely conceptual. In the subset of studies that explicitly connect gatekeeping and AI, most contributions propose theoretical frameworks or

normative assessments rather than systematic empirical analyses (Russell, 2019; Van Dalen, 2023; Voinea, 2025). Moreover, related research often examines automation, personalization, or platform dependencies without explicitly framing these dynamics as gatekeeping (Cools et al., 2023; Napoli, 2015; Nechushtai & Lewis, 2019; Simon, 2022). While these studies underline the need to reconsider gatekeeping in the age of GenAI, we still know little about how such mechanisms operate in practice. This study addresses this gap. Before turning to our analysis, however, it is necessary to first clarify what GenAI is and how it is embedded within the infrastructures of traditional media organizations.

Affordances of GenAI along the media value chain

GenAI refers to machine learning systems that learn the underlying data distributions of text, images, or other modalities to generate novel, contextually coherent outputs (Feuerriegel et al., 2024). These systems enable the automated creation of content across modalities, fundamentally expanding the scope of AI from prediction to production. For media organizations, the significance of GenAI is immediate, as it connects directly to core practices such as the production and distribution of content (Benbya et al., 2024).

To better understand how these applications reshape industry practices, GenAI can be positioned along the media value chain, comprising content *creation* (i.e., generating and editing content), *intermediation* (i.e., packaging, aggregating, and redistributing content), and *reception* (i.e., audience access, exposure, and initial interpretation of content) (Hess & von Walter, 2006). In this sense, GenAI applications can also be distinguished by their primary addressee into publisher-facing, platform-facing, and user-facing applications (Amankwah-Amoah et al., 2024). The rapid commercialization of foundation models, such as OpenAI's GPT series or Google DeepMind's Gemini, accelerates adoption across all three phases of the media value chain (Banh & Strobel, 2023; Simon, 2024). Because most traditional publishers are not large-scale technology developers, adoption usually takes place through systems offered by external providers (Nielsen & Ganter, 2022). Table 1 presents an overview of GenAI use cases along the media value chain.

To analyze how such systems matter in organizational settings, it is helpful to move from technical capabilities to affordances. In the last decade, affordances have increasingly gained prominence in the literature to study the impact of emerging technologies on sociotechnical relations (e.g., Benbunan-Fich, 2019; Claggett et al., 2025; Majchrzak et al., 2013). Affordances denote action possibilities that arise when a technology with particular properties is taken up by situated actors in practice (Volkoff & Strong, 2013). Affordances are relational in nature. They do not reside solely in the artifact, nor solely in the user, but in the encounter between both (Faraj & Azad, 2012; Zammuto

Table 1. Overview of use cases of GenAI based on Chan-Olmsted (2019) and Zwingmann and Hess (2025).

Stage of media value chain	Exemplary GenAI use cases
Creation (Publisher-facing)	- Automated content creation (e.g., article drafting) - GenAI-assisted editing and rewriting - Headline and SEO optimization - Information discovery and research - Bias detection and verification - Data analysis and insights generation - Translation and transcription tasks - Content bundling and curation
Intermediation (Platform-facing)	- GenAI-generated search summaries (answer boxes, overviews) - Integration of publisher content into AI ecosystems via APIs/licensing - Algorithmic filtering of sensitive or restricted domains
Reception (User-facing)	- Personalized and tailored content generation - AI assistants (summarization, Q&A) - Chatbots for interactive content retrieval - Contextual content addition (e.g., explanations, related links) - User-driven co-creation of content via prompts

et al., 2007). This relational perspective has been widely applied to digital platforms, understood as socio-technical environments that enable and constrain practices across different actor groups (Bucher & Helmond, 2018). A similar lens is required to examine GenAI, where affordances arise in the interplay between model capabilities, platform infrastructures, and organizational use. In the following, we focus on a subset of GenAI affordances that is particularly salient for media organizations.

Scalability captures the potential to produce outputs quickly and at volume (Banh & Strobel, 2023), primarily affecting the creation stage, where editorial teams can expand content volume, topical breadth, and variation without proportional increases in cost. *Adaptability* refers to the capacity of models to reshape existing content in response to different inputs and contexts. This affordance is particularly salient in intermediation, where content is summarized, recombined, and reformatted to fit different channels and usage situations. *Interactivity* and *contextuality* describe how responses are shaped in use (Chen & Chan, 2024). Conversational interfaces allow prior turns to function as input to subsequent turns, which creates an ongoing exchange rather than isolated prompts and outputs (Chen & Chan, 2024; Park, 2024). These affordances are most pronounced at the reception stage, where conversational interfaces and contextual signals such as user history enable dynamic, situation-specific responses. Finally, *indeterminacy* highlights that GenAI outputs are not fully predictable, as they emerge from probabilistic sampling processes and hidden internal representations (Park, 2024). This affordance cuts across all stages of the media value chain and introduces uncertainty into content creation, transformation, and consumption.

While all affordances can, in principle, materialize across stages, their positioning in Figure 2 emphasizes analytical prominence rather than exclusivity. This integrated perspective provides the basis for analyzing how GenAI

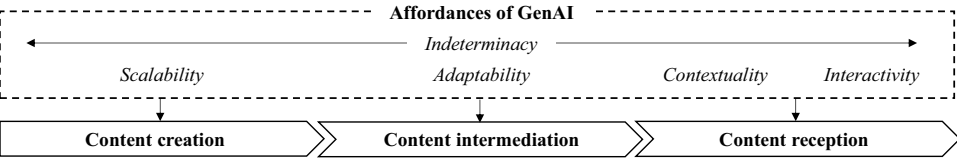


Figure 2. Affordances of GenAI positioned on the media value chain.

reconfigures media processes and reshapes gatekeeping dynamics across the value chain.

While these affordances originate in technical architectures, their concrete implications depend on how they are enacted in practice (Faraj & Azad, 2012; Volkoff & Strong, 2013). This points to an important distinction between system-level dynamics, rooted in infrastructures and model architectures, and human-level dynamics, arising from the ways editors or users mobilize and adapt these systems. Both dimensions are tightly interwoven, as highlighted in recent work on algorithmic discrimination, which shows how models and humans co-evolve in feedback loops (Khanal et al., 2025)

Grounding our analysis in an affordance-based view, we use the media value chain as an analytical anchor to position publisher-facing, platform-facing, and user-facing applications of GenAI. From this conceptual basis which we empirically derive new gatekeeping mechanisms that extend beyond those documented in platform research.

Methodology

The methodology section outlines the research design, case selection, data collection, and data analysis procedures applied in this study. By presenting our methodological choices and procedures transparently, we aim to enhance the traceability and theoretical rigor of the study’s findings.

Research design

We explore how GenAI affects gatekeeping dynamics in the media value chain through an *exploratory multiple-case study* approach (Eisenhardt, 1989; Yin, 2009). Given GenAI’s novelty and transformative potential, the study employs abductive reasoning, which combines empirical observation with theoretical framing to iteratively refine explanations (Sætre & van de Ven, 2021). We derived the initial categories from inductive coding, while iterative analysis of theory and established constructs allowed us to identify and refine emerging themes. The research adopts a multiple-case study design, recognized for its effectiveness in examining phenomena within real-world contexts and identifying patterns across cases (Eisenhardt, 1989; Yin, 2009).

Case selection

Cases were selected through theoretical sampling, such that cases were chosen based on their potential to reveal theoretically informative patterns and contrasts relevant to the research question (Eisenhardt, 1989; Eisenhardt & Graebner, 2007). The case selection was guided by two criteria: (1) demonstrable integration of GenAI technologies for content production and/or reception; (2) a structural reliance on digital intermediaries for content circulation and audience reach (Paré, 2004). Drawing on seven European case organizations from Germany and the UK, we enable analytical replication and establish a robust empirical foundation (Yin, 2009). The sample includes mainstream and premium publishers. The latter are characterized by a focus on high-quality, in-depth journalism aimed at an informed and often niche audience. Mainstream publishers, in contrast, provide general news content tailored to a broad and diverse mass-market audience (Namenwirth, 1969). With this sampling strategy, we aimed to strike a balance between ensuring comparability across cases and capturing sufficient breadth to identify differences, which ultimately allows us to develop more generalizable insights. Table 2 provides an overview of the selected cases.

Primary data collection

Primary data was collected through semi-structured interviews (Myers & Newman, 2007) conducted between May and August 2024, allowing for a comprehensive exploration of the participants' experiences and perspectives. Participants were selected through purposeful sampling (Paré, 2004), ensuring the inclusion of individuals from diverse roles within media organizations. Interviewees were identified and contacted primarily via LinkedIn based on their job descriptions and organizational positions, complemented by referrals that facilitated introductions to additional participants. We interviewed three employees per case: one participant from strategy, operations, and technology, totaling 21 across the seven media organizations. Table 3 provides an overview. The interviews aimed to explore how GenAI reshapes media gatekeeping processes across the value chain. Core topics included the concrete ways in

Table 2. Overview of selected cases.

Case	Content	Reach	Revenue model	Online revenue in m USD	Group revenue in m USD
PublishCo A	Mainstream	National	Advertising	120 m	3000 m
PublishCo B	Premium	National	Hybrid	100 m	350 m
PublishCo C	Mainstream	Regional	Hybrid	75 m	n/a
PublishCo D	Mainstream	National	Advertising	80 m	8000 m
PublishCo E	Premium	International	Paid Content	300 m	470 m
PublishCo F	Mainstream	National	Advertising	130 m	4000 m
PublishCo G	Premium	National	Hybrid	100 m	280 m

Table 3. Overview of conducted interviews.

Case	Interview partners	ID	Length
PublishCo A	Project Manager AI	A1	43 min
	Editor	A2	31 min
	Team Lead AI Video	A3	37 min
PublishCo B	Managing Director	B1	33 min
	Editor	B2	28 min
	Editor Digital	B3	31 min
PublishCo C	Product Manager Digital	C1	32 min
	Editor SEO	C2	40 min
	Data Scientist	C3	41 min
PublishCo D	Edito-in-Chief	D1	30 min
	Editor	D2	28 min
	Editor Audio & Video	D3	36 min
PublishCo E	Director AI	E1	29 min
	Data Journalist	E2	39 min
	Data Product Manager	E3	38 min
PublishCo F	Manager Editorial Concepts	F1	58 min
	Editor	F2	34 min
	AI Lead	F3	34 min
PublishCo G	Innovation Manager	G1	28 min
	Editor	G2	35 min
	Project Manager AI	G3	26 min
Case-spanning interviews	Platform Expert 1	PE1	32 min
	Platform Expert 2	PE2	35 min

which GenAI is used, including the tools and providers involved; perceived changes in relationships with digital intermediaries following the adoption of GenAI; and observed effects of GenAI on content reception and user behavior. Interviewees were asked to reflect on the implications of GenAI for their organization’s journalistic mission, as well as on evolving dependencies on digital intermediaries and GenAI providers. To avoid priming the guideline deliberately avoided gatekeeping terminology and instead used familiar language around workflows, tools, and decision-making. The interviews were held via Zoom or phone and lasted between 26 and 58 minutes and were transcribed verbatim. Transcription was supported by OpenAI’s Whisper and subsequently reviewed and corrected. Interviews conducted in languages other than English were translated with the assistance of DeepL and manually checked for accuracy.

Data triangulation

To further strengthen validity and reliability, we triangulated interview data with a range of secondary sources, including annual reports, press releases, industry analyses, white papers, and podcast episodes (Eisenhardt, 1989). Table 4 provides an overview of these data sources, which ensured that the findings accurately capture the dynamics of GenAI-driven gatekeeping beyond the interview accounts. Theoretical saturation was reached once no new insights emerged from the data, underscoring the comprehensiveness and robustness of the analysis.

Table 4. Overview of secondary data sources.

Data source	Insights on	Quantity
Annual reports	Financial indicators (revenue, profit, segment data), strategic priorities, digital share, investments	6
Press releases	Current developments (products, partnerships, restructuring), strategic initiatives, management statements	20
Industry reports and whitepapers	Market trends (e.g., digital revenues, paid content, advertising market), competitive analyses, positioning in the media sector	11
Podcast episodes	Narratives and assessments from executives and journalists, strategic culture topics, visions of the future	6

Data analysis

To analyze the data, we adopted an abductive reasoning approach (Sætre & van de Ven, 2021). This involved systematically examining the interview data for recurring patterns that resembled core elements of gatekeeping theory, such as points of control over content flows (gates), mechanisms through which selection, shaping, or visibility is enacted, and organizational responses to shifting control across the media value chain. This means that we moved back and forth between our empirical material and existing theory. While the media value chain served as a deductive scaffold to structure the analysis, gatekeeping theory functioned as an analytical lens that guided the interpretation of these emergent patterns rather than as a predefined coding scheme. We first conducted inductive coding, assigning meaningful interview segments to sub-themes that reflected concrete gatekeeping processes. The coding process involved three researchers, who independently coded subsets of the interview material and iteratively compared and discussed emerging interpretations. Through alignment meetings, discrepancies were resolved and the evolving sub-themes were refined into shared understandings. These sub-themes were then iteratively consolidated into broader themes and aggregated dimensions (see Table 5), which structured the emergent framework.

The analytical process followed several rounds of coding and refinement (Eisenhardt, 1989). The coding was performed by three authors who compared their results, discussed divergences, and reached consensus. We began with a process perspective, mapping instances of gatekeeping along the stages of the media value chain. This step helped position the initial set of gatekeeping mechanisms. As overlaps between mechanisms became apparent, and through iterative engagement with prior literature, we concluded that individual gates could be shaped by multiple mechanisms. This insight led us to explicitly distinguish between gates and mechanisms.

Subsequent discussions among the authors revealed that these mechanisms rarely operate in isolation. We therefore added a relational level of analysis, capturing how mechanisms interact, by reinforcing, triggering, or mitigating one another. Furthermore, we observed that media organizations develop various response strategies to cope with new gatekeeping dynamics. Initially

Findings

The findings are presented in two steps: first, a condensed overview of the within-case analyses, and second, a cross-case analysis that synthesizes insights across publishers to abstract how GenAI reshapes gatekeeping along the media value chain.

Within-case analysis

To provide a structured overview of the cases, we first conducted detailed within-case analyses of each publisher's approach to GenAI and their perceptions. These analyses highlight organizational stances, adoption intensity, use cases, and perceived concerns as well as threats. Given their length, the full within-case narratives are included in the [Appendix](#). [Table 6](#) provides a comparative overview of the seven cases and summarizes key dimensions of GenAI use that inform the subsequent cross-case analysis. For each media organization, the table captures the overall stance toward GenAI, the intensity of its use, the dominant use cases, the primary concerns associated with these applications, and the perceived level of threat posed by GenAI.

Cross-case analysis

In the following, we present the cross-case findings of our study. Building on the within-case analyses (see [Appendix](#)), we synthesize how GenAI reshapes gatekeeping by transforming existing mechanisms and triggering new ones. Our analysis centers on how publishers experience and navigate these

Table 6. Overview of within-case findings.

Case	GenAI stance	Use intensity	Use cases	Primary concerns	Perceived threat
PublishCo A	Proactive	High	Drafting, reformatting, large-scale automation	Loss of visibility via search engines	High
PublishCo B	Cautious / Exploratory	Medium	Headlines, teasers, inspiration	Copyright misuse, visibility erosion	Medium
PublishCo C	Skeptical	Low	Summarizing, format adaptation	Reliability, loss of control	Medium
PublishCo D	Pragmatic	Medium / High	Workflow automation, multi-channel adaptation	Content oversupply, loss of differentiation	High
PublishCo E	Selective / Strategic	Medium	Analytical augmentation, summarization	Content misuse, attribution	Low
PublishCo F	Pragmatic / Expansive	High	Drafting, reformatting, large-scale automation	Market saturation, loss of attribution	High
PublishCo G	Cautious but Open	Medium	Headlines, teasers, inspiration	Zero-click summaries, loss of value	Medium

mechanisms, and how AI providers affect their sense of control, visibility, and editorial agency. To structure the analysis, we conceptualize gates as “intervention points” in the media value chain where GenAI intervenes, and gatekeeping mechanisms as the processes through which content is enabled, constrained, or reconfigured. As Figure 3 shows, our analysis identifies two additional gates: the *creation gate*, where infrastructural and editorial constraints emerge upstream, and the *reception gate*, where personalization and conversational systems shape downstream access and visibility. We proceed sequentially along the value chain, outlining each gate’s function and the associated mechanisms. Finally, we examine publishers’ response strategies, which we treat separately given their transversal character that cuts across gates and mechanisms.

Creation gate

The creation gate marks the point where journalistic content is initially produced and where GenAI most directly enters editorial workflows. This gate is driven by two distinct gatekeeping mechanisms that operate on different levels. Infrastructural gatekeeping arises from the system logics of GenAI and the broader platform ecosystems in which publishers are embedded, making them subject to externally imposed rules rather than their own agency. Editorial gatekeeping, in contrast, reflects the agency of journalists and editors who define the boundaries of automation, maintain standards of review, and safeguard professional identity. Together, these mechanisms illustrate how the creation gate is simultaneously shaped by system-level and human-level practices. As GenAI becomes increasingly embedded in the production process, the balance between these levels begins to shift. What has traditionally been understood as a phase of content creation now gives way to a mode of *information provision*. Textual material is often pre-generated by GenAI systems and only subsequently reviewed, curated, and contextualized by human editors. In this way, the Creation Gate is redefined: rather than marking the origin of journalistic content, it becomes a point where

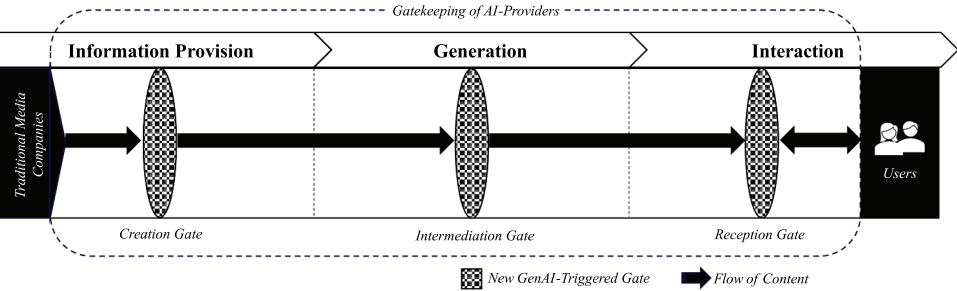


Figure 3. GenAI-induced gates.

information is provisionally supplied by GenAI and then selectively refined through editorial intervention.

Infrastructural gatekeeping. Infrastructural gatekeeping refers to the growing reliance of publishers on external providers for the technological backbone of GenAI. These dependencies go far beyond typical software usage, but they extend into foundational elements like model architecture, data infrastructure, and integration logic. As such, GenAI tools do not merely assist journalistic work; they reconfigure the conditions under which it takes place. This grants platform companies, who own and maintain these systems, a powerful upstream role in shaping editorial production, well before human editorial judgment enters the process. “[*The huge training data is*] exactly why we value these models [...]. We can’t train them ourselves. We are a company that applies technology on a large scale. We are not a company that develops technology on a big scale” (F1). This technical dependency is driven by internal resource limitations as well as market dynamics that demand speed, scalability, and interoperability. Publishers feel compelled to adopt external systems to keep up with evolving industry standards. As one interviewee puts it, resistance is not a real option when competitiveness is at stake: “*I think we will have no choice but to use platforms such as OpenAI, Llama from Meta, or Gemini from Google in order to remain competitive in the market*” (A1).

Gatekeeping manifests as AI infrastructure becomes entangled with publishers’ everyday operations. Providers actively shape integration pathways through licensing models, preferential support, and technical bundling (e.g., with Microsoft 365). Over time, publishers find themselves embedded in ecosystems that are difficult to exit, reconfigure, or negotiate. This asymmetry becomes more structural as consolidation progresses. Some publishers reflect on their relative powerlessness within this evolving ecosystem. Their visibility, influence, and long-term control are dwarfed by the scale of the infrastructures they rely on. “*The big players are getting bigger, and in 10- or 20-years’ time, there will probably be even fewer platforms—but they will be even more powerful. I find that rather worrying. And it has to be said that, as an individual medium, we are just a blip on the map for Meta or similar companies*” (B3).

Publishers aim at diversifying their technological partnerships or avoiding exclusivity altogether. Others seek more controllable alternatives from local or European providers. These choices reflect attempts to retain agency in selecting, combining, and governing AI tools, even when internal capabilities are limited. The goal is to balance participation in technological innovation with resilience against lock-in. “*We try to spread the risk—to put it diplomatically. [...] Different language models can also do different things well. And we try to find out or filter out what is most suitable for the respective use case*” (G1). Equally, publishers stress that exclusivity is avoided to accommodate a rapidly shifting landscape.

Editorial gatekeeping. Editorial gatekeeping refers to the structural influence GenAI exerts over content creation by shaping the very process through which journalistic outputs are produced. While earlier forms of gatekeeping centered on human editorial selection, AI now predefines formats, tones, and workflows. In doing so, it displaces traditional editorial judgment. This shifts power upstream to model defaults, prompt structures, and content templates, thus constituting a new GenAI-driven form of editorial control. GenAI is broadly used for routine tasks where the models perform reliably, such as headline generation, summaries, and SEO-optimized blurbs. “*AI is not good at creating qualitative content, but it is very good at creating quantitative content*” (B3). Publishers use AI to adapt content across languages and formats, extending reach into new markets (e.g., F1). In more advanced cases, content management systems (CMS) systems are connected to fine-tuned models on internal article databases (e.g., C3), which illustrate how AI’s gatekeeping becomes more individualized and intrusive than ever before. Gatekeeping is enacted depending on the way AI is integrated into editorial workflows. Some newsrooms apply an “AI-first” approach: AI generates a first draft, which is then edited by journalists. Others use a “human-first” approach: human-authored articles are optimized, translated, or adapted by AI systems. In both cases, editorial agency is reframed. It is less around initial creation anymore, but around review, adaptation, and correction. This reordering of tasks gives AI a formative role in defining content flow, structure, and style. An interviewee explains how they reuse well-working prompts as templates to ease content creation: “*If I have a medical text, I use the medical template – for a celebrity text, I use a different one*” (A3).

A central concern relates to the growing opacity of GenAI systems, which makes it difficult for publishers to understand or control how content is processed and presented. This lack of transparency undermines the internal confidence publishers have in their own workflows. Publishers also fear a flattening of editorial variety. As GenAI tools become widely adopted, content production risks being standardized across outlets, leading to outputs that increasingly sound alike. One interviewee explained: “*Because if [...] lots of companies are using the same tools to create content, [...] we all consume from more or less the same pool of information*” (E3). This risk is further amplified by the recursive logic of the models themselves: as GenAI-generated text circulates online and becomes part of future training data, models begin to learn from their own outputs, reinforcing homogeneity and diminishing diversity. The concern is compounded by the perception of an ecosystem already saturated with low-value outputs: “*The internet is flooded with AI-generated, SEO-optimized, content-free pages*” (B3).

In response, publishers highlight their superiority in terms of quality, credibility, and creativity, emphasizing that core elements of journalistic judgment cannot be automated: “*Would Picasso have been a more creative*

person with the help of AI? No, he couldn't have been – because creativity cannot be added up. The fresh words come from us” (F1). While publishers warn that unchecked AI risks producing an ever-growing flood of self-referential and homogenized content, they position themselves as providers of originality and verification. They emphasize niches where GenAI has limited advantages, such as highly local, time-sensitive, or investigative reporting, and reinforce their editorial identity as guarantors of professional standards and truth. In an environment where GenAI personalization risks privileging “likability” over accuracy, differentiation thus becomes a strategy of self-assertion and distinctiveness.

Intermediation gate

The intermediation gate captures how GenAI reshapes the ways in which audiences access journalistic content. Traditionally, intermediation was primarily about visibility: search engines and social platforms determined whether and how publishers' content appeared in ranked lists or feeds. In GenAI-enabled environments, visibility becomes even more decisive, since generated answers or overviews often reference only a very limited set of sources. Moreover, with the integration of GenAI into these systems, a new layer of mediation emerges. Content access increasingly happens through GenAI-enabled features that summarize, paraphrase, or directly generate information in response to user queries. In this sense, the gate extends its function from a filter of visibility to content modification. This enables a new form of *recomposition gatekeeping*, as GenAI systems disassemble, reassemble, and reframe content before it reaches the audience. Importantly, this also means that intermediation itself takes on characteristics of content *generation*. What used to be a phase of pure distribution now produces novel outputs, thereby pushing the locus of creation further downstream in the media value chain.

Recomposition gatekeeping. At the intermediation gate, we identify a distinct mechanism of recomposition gatekeeping. GenAI systems increasingly generate synthetic summaries and direct answers that satisfy information needs on the spot. In this sense, intermediaries now act as content generators in their own right. Media companies risk being relegated to the role of mere information providers, feeding material into systems that reassemble it without their involvement. As one editor warned, *“If everything is simply scraped and summarized, we no longer need newspapers” (C3).*

The most immediate effect of this transformation is the rise of zero-click searches, where audiences consume GenAI-generated outputs without visiting the underlying websites. One publisher described the outcome: *“Although sources are displayed there, the content presented is usually sufficient for the average user. [...] Traffic to the actual websites drops, and with it the*

advertising revenue” (G1). For many publishers, this dynamic undermines the very foundation of their digital business models. “*Google search as we knew it is dead. And that has massive implications, because being at the top of the search results used to be a business model*” (Platform Expert 1). In other words, recomposition gatekeeping not only changes how content is accessed but also destabilizes the economic models that have long sustained digital publishing.

Once carefully curated and contextualized by editors, content is now rephrased, shortened, or polished by GenAI systems in ways that publishers cannot oversee: “*There is a danger that someone will take our content, modify it using AI and pass it on as their own information, simply taking over our work and adding a little polish or leaving passages out we think are important for context*” (F3). What troubles publishers is the broader loss of editorial control: they no longer determine how their work is presented, which parts are emphasized or omitted, and whether the final output reflects professional values. “*Basically, as a media company, we are completely cut off*” (F1).

A further concern relates to the uncertain rules of source inclusion and exclusion in GenAI outputs. Whereas in the era of SEO, publishers developed a relatively clear understanding of how to optimize content to appear prominently in search rankings, there is far less transparency around how sources are selected and displayed in AI-generated summaries. This lack of clarity forces publishers into a reactive position, uncertain about how to present or adapt their content in order to remain visible within AI-mediated environments.

As a response, publishers distance themselves from GenAI-driven intermediation where it undermines their control over content access, presentation, and monetization. “*At some point, you have to take a stand. Distance yourself or perhaps even fight back*” (F3). In some cases, this extends to legal action against AI providers, reflecting growing resistance to the unauthorized use and transformation of journalistic content. This is a strategy of resistance through which publishers seek to contest platform dominance and protect their economic foundations.

Reception gate

The reception gate captures the stage where audiences encounter journalistic content. Traditionally, reception was marked by a primarily passive mode of consumption, as readers, viewers, or listeners accessed finished media products distributed via print, broadcast, or digital platforms. With the rise of the internet and platform-based media, this mode of reception already became less linear, as user-generated content, social interaction, and algorithmic curation introduced feedback loops and personalization into news consumption. However, with the rise of GenAI, these dynamics are further intensified. Audiences increasingly engage with AI-mediated interfaces that provide

information in conversational form or tailor it through algorithmic personalization. As a result, the reception phase gradually shifts from predominantly receptive consumption toward more *interactive* forms of engagement, in which news consumption becomes more dialogical and adaptive. This shift triggers two distinct gatekeeping mechanisms. First, conversational gatekeeping refers to the way AI agents increasingly act as intermediaries, delivering information in response to user prompts and thereby replacing traditional search-and-click behavior with dialogue. Second, personalization gatekeeping captures how algorithmic systems filter, rank, and tailor information to individual profiles, shaping not only what users see but also what remains invisible.

Conversational gatekeeping. Conversational gatekeeping unfolds as a new form of mediation in which access to news is increasingly organized through user-driven interactions with GenAI systems. Unlike traditional digital news environments, where audiences navigated websites, feeds, or lists of links curated by publishers and platforms, conversational interfaces restructure information access around iterative dialogue. Users no longer primarily consume predefined journalistic products, but actively steer information retrieval through prompts, follow-up questions, and conversational intent that dynamically shape the AI-generated response.

This fundamentally alters the logic of media consumption. Rather than selecting among visible content options that have already been structured by publishers or platforms, users increasingly engage in one-to-one conversations with AI systems that synthesize, contextualize, and personalize information in real time. One interviewee described this as “*a new interaction model: language, one-to-one dialogue*” (F1). In this setting, journalistic content becomes less relevant as a standalone destination and more relevant as modular source material embedded into conversational exchanges.

Conversational gatekeeping therefore shifts substantial agency toward users, whose conversational choices increasingly influence how information is retrieved, structured, prioritized, and presented. As one interviewee emphasized, “*Users play a very, very important role. How do they want to consume content in the future?*” (A3). This creates a fundamentally different relationship between audiences and news content: information is no longer encountered as a fixed editorial product, but co-constructed through ongoing interaction between users and AI systems.

For media organizations, this emerging interaction paradigm challenges established assumptions about how journalistic content is produced, distributed, and consumed. A platform expert argued that “*media organizations do need to deal with the kind of new paradigm that’s coming.*” Publishers increasingly face the challenge of designing content for AI-mediated conversational environments. One interviewee described this broader transition as

a movement toward AI-mediated interaction: “*People were used to clicking on links. [...] In the future, it will be a personal AI agent that people use*” (D1).

Personalization gatekeeping. A second mechanism at the reception gate is personalization gatekeeping, where GenAI systems tailor outputs based on user profiles, behavioral histories, and contextual signals. Unlike conversational gatekeeping, which is explicitly driven by user prompts, personalization is system-driven and unfolds primarily in the background. Every prior interaction with an AI agent shapes subsequent answers, often in ways that remain invisible to the user. In traditional reception, all audiences accessed broadly the same set of news, and even in platform environments, personalization was primarily a matter of filtering and ranking existing articles. By contrast, GenAI personalization occurs automatically for each user, whether or not users actively request such tailoring. As one interviewee explained, “*Based on the individual, we receive the content that the system deems appropriate*” (Secondary Data, News Article). This points to the crucial dynamic of personalization: while the initial query is triggered by the user, it is ultimately the system that determines what counts as an appropriate output.

Building on this, publishers repeatedly emphasized the opacity of GenAI personalization as one of their most pressing concerns. Their sense of disempowerment is vividly expressed in the words of another interviewee: “*As publishers, we tend to be spectators, waiting to see how the dice fall*” (F1). Interviewees frequently compared this development to the personalization logics of social media, but it is now pushed to a new extreme. While Platforms such as Facebook or TikTok already filter news streams according to user interests, GenAI performs hyperpersonalization. An industry report described GenAI as taking “*what we know from social media to the extreme,*” warning that it risks confining users ever more tightly to what appears relevant to their interests (Secondary Data, Industry Report).

Beyond this structural narrowing, the most far-reaching consequence of personalization gatekeeping lies in its normative filtering. GenAI systems not only predict what users are likely to engage with but also satisfy their psychological motives, regardless of whether the content aligns with journalistic standards. This creates a feedback loop in which factual accuracy becomes secondary: “*The user gets exactly what they want to hear [...] whether it is true or not is often no longer of interest to them*” (F1). Secondary sources echo this concern, noting that GenAI “*is optimized for likability, not for truth,*” as reinforcement learning increasingly tunes outputs toward what is agreeable rather than what is correct (Secondary Data, Industry Report).

Still, rather than completely resisting AI-mediated consumption, publishers tend to incorporate conversational and personalized modes of access in their own offerings to align with changing user expectations. “*We started very early on with [...] integrating a chatbot [...]. Call it deliberate cannibalization. But*

before you lose your readers to others, you'd rather do it yourself" (F3). Moreover, there are also approaches to cooperate with AI providers, for instance through licensing agreements or content partnerships: *"If you can't beat them, join them"* (A3). This strategy reflects a pragmatic orientation toward GenAI, particularly at the reception stage, where adapting to new modes of interaction becomes critical for maintaining audience access and relevance.

Discussion

In this study, we examined how GenAI reshapes gatekeeping within the media value chain from the perspective of publishers. While traditional gatekeeping research has primarily emphasized intermediation, our analysis shows that GenAI introduces gates at three stages of the media value chain: creation, intermediation, and reception, where new points of control emerge (Khanal et al., 2025; Simon, 2024). Across these gates, we distinguish five concrete GenAI-triggered gatekeeping mechanisms: infrastructural, editorial, recombination, conversational, and personalization-related. Our findings demonstrate that GenAI both creates entirely new gatekeeping dynamics and intensifies existing ones, thereby reconfiguring the relationship between publishers, intermediaries, and audiences. In the discussion, we elaborate on three main insights: (1) the emergence of new gatekeeping mechanisms, (2) the reconfiguration of media activities across the MVC, and (3) shifting power distributions in the media ecosystem.

Emergence of new gatekeeping mechanisms in the media value chain

Prior research on digital media has primarily emphasized gatekeeping at the intermediation stage, where algorithms and platforms filter, rank, and distribute content to audiences (Wallace, 2018). In this literature, gatekeeping was often conceptualized as a central bottleneck in the media value chain, located between content production and reception (e.g., Gillespie, 2018; Napoli, 2015). Our findings show that the rise of GenAI expands this configuration: Gatekeeping no longer occurs only in the middle of the media value chain, but also significantly earlier during content creation and later during content reception. This shift is induced by the affordances of GenAI, which alter when and how control is exercised over information flows. Our analysis centers on a key distinction between system-driven and human-driven gatekeeping mechanisms. System-driven mechanisms originate in technical infrastructures, model architectures, and algorithmic processes. They operate largely beyond the direct influence of media organizations and are therefore harder to contest or steer. Human-driven mechanisms, by contrast, are initiated through editorial decisions or user interactions with GenAI systems. They remain open

to intervention, negotiation, and strategic shaping. This distinction matters because it highlights where publishers can exert agency and where control shifts decisively toward technological systems. Moreover, because gates can emerge at both levels simultaneously, their interaction can amplify or weaken gatekeeping effects across the media value chain.

As illustrated in [Figure 4](#), we reframe gatekeeping as a multi-sited process distributed across the media value chain (Barzilai-Nahon, 2008) and identify three gates in the media value chain: creation, intermediation, and reception. At the creation gate, scalability and customizability affordances allow GenAI to reshape content provision. Editorial teams can generate drafts, expand topical coverage, or rewrite texts at volume (Amankwah-Amoah et al., 2024; Pavlik, 2023), but in doing so, they become dependent on underlying infrastructures and model behavior. This produces infrastructural gatekeeping, which is primarily system-driven, as access to models and their technical boundaries constrain what is possible. This is particularly evident in cases where publishers described feeling compelled to adopt external model infrastructures despite concerns about dependency and loss of control. It also gives rise to editorial gatekeeping, which is more human-driven, as AI-assisted production processes influence textual form and style (Riemer & Peter, 2024). This dynamic is visible in the AI-first workflows identified across cases, where the sequence of creation and editorial judgment is effectively reversed: AI generates the initial output, and human editors assume a corrective rather than a generative role.

At the intermediation gate, GenAI reinforces and transforms existing dynamics. Here, adaptability allows models to reconfigure content ex post by summarizing, reformatting, or recombining pieces for new contexts (Epstein, Hertzmann, Creativity, et al., 2023; Wessel et al., 2025). Where earlier work on gatekeeping largely addressed dynamics associated with discriminative algorithms embedded in digital platforms our findings point to a further intensification of these dynamics through GenAI. For instance, Hermida’s (2020) concept of post-publication gatekeeping highlights how platforms shape the visibility and prominence of news while still largely

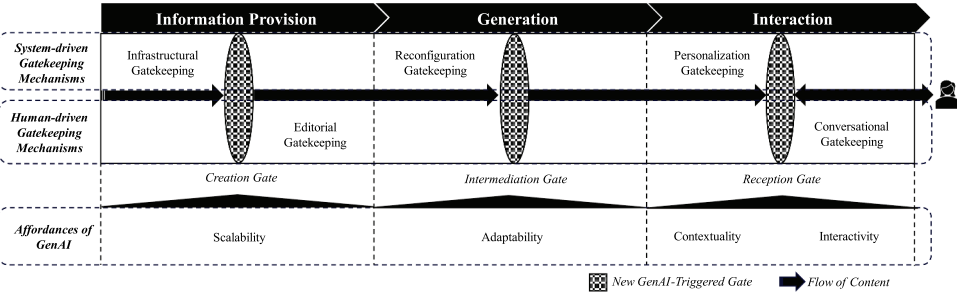


Figure 4. GenAI-Induced gatekeeping mechanisms.

preserving the click-through to publisher sites as the dominant user journey. By contrast, recomposition gatekeeping captures how GenAI increasingly decouples news consumption from publisher-controlled formats and contexts. This mechanism is predominantly system-driven, but its impact depends on how human actors (e.g., editors) adapt their practices to algorithmically reshaped formats, a dynamic that others have described as editorial overrides (Voinea, 2025). At the reception gate, contextuality and interactivity affordances introduce new downstream control points. User-facing GenAI systems such as chatbots or search-integrated assistants generate personalized, context-sensitive outputs based on prompts, histories, and profiles (Chen & Chan, 2024; Park, 2024). This results in human-driven conversational gatekeeping as user inputs guide the flow of content, and system-driven personalization gatekeeping as algorithmic profiles and contextual signals determine what is returned (Simon, 2024). While these two mechanisms strongly resonate with prior work on conversational gatekeeping (Salonen et al., 2023), our analysis further differentiates these dynamics by distinguishing between human-driven and system-driven gatekeeping effects. In this configuration, editorial intent and brand identity risk becoming increasingly invisible within AI-generated interactions. This concern was consistently voiced across cases, where publishers described themselves as increasingly passive observers of AI-mediated distribution, unable to oversee how their content is selected, reframed, or omitted in generated outputs.

The identified gates do not operate in isolation but are deeply interdependent, creating recursive loops across the media value chain. Upstream in the media value chain infrastructural gatekeeping conditions the scope of editorial gatekeeping. Here, dependencies on model access, training data, or system affordances determine which editorial practices are even feasible (cf. Gillespie, 2018; Young & Hermida, 2024). Our findings show that publishers diversified across multiple model providers specifically to retain flexibility in their editorial workflows, and where consolidation among platform companies was perceived as a structural threat to editorial autonomy. Downstream in the media value chain, conversational and reconfiguration gatekeeping mutually reinforce each other. Here, the human initiation of conversations directly activates system-driven recomposition processes, showing how agency and system capabilities are tightly entangled (Chen & Chan, 2024; Faraj & Azad, 2012). Across cases, publishers observed how zero-click behavior triggered by conversational interfaces directly undermines traffic and advertising revenue, illustrating how user-driven interactions at the reception gate produce systemic consequences at the intermediation gate. Similarly, personalization gatekeeping, which relies on contextual and behavioral signals, is intensified by conversational dynamics: every interaction generates new data that feeds back into personalization algorithms, amplifying their influence over what users ultimately see. Publisher strategies further reshape these relationships by

extending control across stages. Even though prior research has clearly distinguished between publisher-facing and user-facing applications of GenAI at the level of use cases (Amankwah-Amoah et al., 2024), our findings suggest that their implications can extend beyond these boundaries. When publishers introduce their own conversational interfaces, infrastructural gatekeeping expands downstream into the reception stage, as publishers themselves become providers of user-facing AI environments. Our data shows that several publishers pursued exactly this logic, deliberately integrating chatbots into their own platforms as a strategy of deliberate cannibalization, seeking to retain audience access before losing readers to external AI systems entirely. Taken together, these relationships show that GenAI not only multiplies the sites of gatekeeping across the media value chain but also creates interdependencies among the mechanisms themselves, making gatekeeping increasingly networked (cf. Voinea, 2025). These entanglements demonstrate that gatekeeping in the age of GenAI is best understood as a relational process, where mechanisms reinforce, trigger, or mitigate each other across stages of the media value chain (Barzilai-Nahon, 2008; Wallace, 2018).

Reconfiguration of media work across the media value chain

The introduction of GenAI has also blurred the formerly distinct boundaries between phases of the media value chain (Pavlik, 2023; Prien & Goldhammer, 2024). In traditional workflows, content creation, intermediation, and reception were largely separable stages, each with specific practices and actors. However, our findings suggest a transformation of these activities. The creation phase is now increasingly characterized by *information provision*, where the central task shifts from producing polished narratives to supplying systems with raw data, facts, or templates that can be recombined and reused by GenAI (Riemer & Peter, 2024). Editorial style and identity become secondary as publishers adapt their practices to suit the input needs of generative models. Content is increasingly designed as “input-ready” rather than “output-polished,” a shift from storytelling to data provisioning. This was observable in our cases, as publishers increasingly described their role as supplying structured inputs, such as templates or standardized formats, rather than crafting finished editorial products. This alters journalistic routines and has implications for editorial autonomy and voice (Riemer & Peter, 2024). During intermediation, we observe a hybridization of functions, where intermediation no longer entails mere curation but also real-time creation, blurring the line between infrastructure and authorship. This dynamic was particularly visible in the recomposition gatekeeping mechanism identified at the intermediation gate, where GenAI systems paraphrase, summarize, and reassemble publisher content without editorial involvement, effectively assuming an authorial function. Thus, the phase is increasingly defined by *generation*. Where it once

centered on filtering, ranking, and distributing existing content, GenAI introduces on-demand production and synthesis triggered by user queries. This creates a continuous and iterative flow between content provision and recomposition. At the reception stage, *interaction* becomes the dominant activity: consumption turns into a dialogue between users and systems, in which meaning is co-constructed through prompts, contextualization, and personalized outputs (Chen & Chan, 2024). Across cases, publishers recognized this shift as a fundamental change in the user relationship, noting that audiences increasingly expect content to be delivered through conversational interfaces rather than encountered as fixed editorial products. The phases of the media shift around the activities of provision, generation, and interaction, replacing earlier assumptions of clearly segmented production, distribution, and reception.

These changes point to a platformization of creativity (Benbya et al., 2024; Epstein, Hertzmann, Akten, et al., 2023), where the act of creating content becomes inseparable from aligning with system architectures. Media companies must now optimize not only for ranking algorithms but for generative model architectures and embedding structures, raising new questions about standardization, editorial sovereignty, and the evolution of professional norms in journalism (Simon, 2022).

Shifting power distributions in the media ecosystem

The dynamics of gatekeeping have historically been closely tied to power. In the pre-digital era, traditional media organizations exercised primary control over the selection, framing, and dissemination of information (Shoemaker & Vos, 2009). With the rise of digital platforms, much of this control shifted to intermediaries, which became central nodes for circulation and monetization (Van Dalen, 2023). Search engines and social networks determined visibility through algorithmic filtering and ranking, effectively positioning themselves as new gatekeepers of public attention (Gawer, 2022; Gillespie, 2010). GenAI accelerates and deepens this redistribution (Voinea, 2025). Intermediaries and AI providers scale their influence through generalized technical affordances such as scalability, adaptability, and contextuality, which enable them to intervene at multiple stages of the media value chain. In some cases, these are the same actors that already dominated intermediation; in others, new providers claim central roles. This was reflected in our data, where publishers described their dependency on a small number of external model providers as both technically unavoidable and strategically concerning, with some explicitly anticipating further consolidation of platform power over the coming decades. Either way, power is increasingly concentrated with those who control infrastructures and models. While intermediaries expand their reach through scalable infrastructures, publishers operate within narrower constraints

(Simon, 2024). Several publishers articulated this asymmetry directly, describing themselves as marginal actors relative to the scale of the infrastructures they rely on, with limited leverage to negotiate terms, influence model behavior, or exit existing dependencies. At the same time, end-users gain unprecedented influence, a dynamic described as “user-centric gatekeeping” (Voinea, 2025). Through conversational and personalization gatekeeping, they actively shape outputs via prompts, histories, and contextual cues (Fui-Hoon Nah et al., 2023). This user agency further displaces publishers, whose editorial framing becomes less relevant when audiences consume AI-mediated responses rather than original articles. This dynamic was evident in publishers’ concerns about zero-click behavior at the intermediation gate, where AI-generated summaries satisfy user information needs without redirecting traffic to publisher sites, effectively rendering editorial framing invisible. Currently, the power asymmetry is clearly tilted toward AI providers, who dominate infrastructurally and economically. Yet, this imbalance may not be stable. GenAI systems remain dependent on access to large amounts of high-quality data, and media organizations are among the few actors capable of producing such content at scale (Epstein, Hertzmann, Akten, et al., 2023). If models increasingly rely on self-generated or synthetic outputs, their quality and originality risk deteriorating. In such a scenario, publishers’ informational assets become more critical, potentially forcing a renegotiation of dependencies. Some publishers already anticipated this dynamic, pursuing licensing agreements and content partnerships with AI providers as a pragmatic strategy to secure recognition and compensation for their informational assets. The outcome of ongoing legal and regulatory disputes, such as the New York Times lawsuit against OpenAI, will be decisive in shaping whether publishers can reclaim bargaining power.

The response strategies identified in our study resonate with broader patterns documented in the literature on media evolution and technological change. Previous research has shown that media organizations typically respond to disruptive technologies through a combination of adaptation, differentiation, and resistance (Doyle, 2013; Nielsen & Ganter, 2022). Our findings suggest that publishers employ similar strategies in response to GenAI. Differentiation strategies, such as emphasizing originality, investigative reporting, local expertise, and editorial credibility, mirror earlier attempts to maintain relevance in increasingly platformized media environments (Nieborg & Poell, 2018). At the same time, publishers pursue adaptive strategies by experimenting with conversational interfaces, licensing agreements, and collaborations with AI providers, reflecting patterns of accommodation that have previously characterized publisher-platform relations (Nielsen & Ganter, 2018). Finally, legal actions and deliberate distancing from AI-mediated distribution channels illustrate forms of resistance aimed at protecting editorial autonomy and economic sustainability. Taken together, these

responses suggest that GenAI intensifies existing strategic tensions between adaptation and autonomy that have accompanied earlier waves of digital transformation in the media industry.

In sum, GenAI reconfigures the balance of power within the media ecosystem. Publishers experience structural disempowerment, intermediaries and AI providers consolidate infrastructural control, and users gain at the reception stage. These power shifts are inseparable from role shifts. They also raise fundamental questions of accountability (Van Dalen, 2023): Who is responsible for what is said when content is co-produced by humans and machines? And how can publishers preserve distinctiveness and credibility when their content is mediated, transformed, or replaced by generative systems?

Conclusion

This study sheds light on the transformative role of GenAI in media ecosystems, contributing new perspectives on gatekeeping, power relations, and research on media and AI, while highlighting practical and societal implications for media organizations navigating these changes.

Theoretical contribution

Contribution to gatekeeping theory

We contribute to gatekeeping theory (Shoemaker & Vos, 2009) by reexamining it in the context of GenAI, which reshapes when, where, and how control over information flows is exercised. Earlier research has emphasized intermediation as the central bottleneck in the media value chain, where platforms and algorithms filter, rank, and distribute content (Barzilai-Nahon, 2008; Gillespie, 2010; Wallace, 2018). Recent conceptual work has extended this view to algorithmic environments (Nechushtai & Lewis, 2019; Voinea, 2025). Our study advances this debate by providing empirical evidence from publishers and by systematically mapping how GenAI reconfigures gatekeeping across the media value chain.

First, we add to gatekeeping theory by demonstrating the emergence of new mechanisms and their distribution across multiple stages of the media value chain. While earlier research located gatekeeping primarily at the point of intermediation, our findings show that GenAI also introduces control points upstream at content creation (through infrastructural and editorial mechanisms) and downstream at reception (through interactional, contextual, and visibility-related mechanisms) (Carlson, 2018; Nechushtai & Lewis, 2019; Voinea, 2025). This expansion broadens the scope of gatekeeping from a single bottleneck to a multi-sited configuration that spans creation, intermediation, and reception.

Second, we contribute by showing that these mechanisms are not discrete but interdependent. Prior theory has emphasized networked gatekeeping as relational processes between gatekeepers and the gated, with shifting roles and dependencies (Barzilai-Nahon, 2008). Our analysis adds a new layer by demonstrating that gatekeeping mechanisms themselves are networked: infrastructural constraints upstream condition what editorial practices are feasible, while downstream personalization and conversational mechanisms feed back into intermediation by generating data traces that reshape visibility. Gatekeeping must therefore be understood as a layered and recursive process, where mechanisms trigger, amplify, or limit one another.

Third, we extend gatekeeping theory by distinguishing between system-driven and human-driven gates. Existing studies have emphasized the growing role of algorithms in shaping editorial flows (Lewis et al., 2019; Napoli, 2015; Wallace, 2018) but have not systematically differentiated where human agency remains present and where it is structurally limited. Our findings show that some mechanisms are system-driven (arising from infrastructures, model architectures, and algorithmic processes), while others are human-driven (editorial practices or user interactions), even though they are technologically mediated. This distinction clarifies where publishers can still exert agency and where control decisively shifts to technological systems (Munoriyarwa & de Lima-Santos, 2025).

Contribution to power asymmetries in media ecosystems

We also contribute to research on dependencies and power in media ecosystems, a longstanding theme in media management and media economics (Doyle, 2013; Ihlebæk & Sundet, 2023; Nieborg & Poell, 2018). Earlier work has shown how digital platforms have restructured media markets by controlling distribution, audience access, and monetization (Gillespie, 2010; Nieborg & Poell, 2018). Our findings demonstrate that with the rise of GenAI, such dependencies intensify and expand. Rather than only replacing linearity with platform logics (Hess & Nserat, 2025; Nieborg & Poell, 2018; Nielsen & Ganter, 2022), GenAI reconfigures the media value chain by reorganizing media activities around provision, generation, and interaction. At the creation stage, publishers increasingly act as providers of system-ready inputs rather than producers of polished outputs (Riemer & Peter, 2024). At intermediation, GenAI enables dynamic generation and recomposition of content, altering temporality and editorial authority in ways that echo concerns about algorithmic judgment (Carlson, 2018; Usher, 2018). At reception, content consumption becomes interactive, with user prompts and contextual cues shaping outputs and their perceived relevance (Amankwah-Amoah et al., 2024; Pavlik, 2023).

Due to this shift, AI providers not only control distribution but also intervene in content creation and reception (Mayer et al., 2025; Wessel et al., 2025).

Publishers' autonomy is weakened both upstream and downstream on the value chain, confirming prior observations on structural dependence while extending them to new GenAI-driven contexts. In this way, we extend the platformization literature by highlighting that GenAI multiplies the sites and modalities of dependency. In parallel, the commercial logics of AI integration further destabilize traditional boundaries between editorial and business domains. As studies on editorial-commercial integration have shown, news organizations already operate under a new norm of cross-functional alignment (Cornia et al., 2020). AI exacerbates this by embedding content decisions in platform- and infrastructure-driven business models (Moran & Shaikh, 2022). As AI providers leverage scale and infrastructural control to shape the conditions of media work, users gain agency through interactive, personalized systems. Publishers, by contrast, experience a “loss-loss” dynamic: power that was previously at least partially in their domain is now ceded upstream to AI providers and downstream to users, leaving them structurally weakened on both sides of the media value chain (Thäsler-Kordonouri & Koliska, 2025). By highlighting this dual erosion of influence, we extend prior literature on power asymmetries. In doing so, our study also contributes to research on media organizations' responses to technological disruption (Doyle, 2013; Nieborg & Poell, 2018; Nielsen & Ganter, 2018) by showing that these strategies now operate simultaneously across multiple gates and can coexist within the same organization, extending prior accounts that have typically examined publisher responses at a single stage of the media value chain.

Contribution to research on media and AI

Finally, we contribute to the emerging research stream on media and AI by foregrounding an affordance perspective on GenAI, which has begun to map the implications of AI for media management and journalism. Much of the existing work has examined how AI is used in practice, for example, mapping applications across content creation, personalization, and newsroom routines (e.g., Chan-Olmsted, 2019; Pavlik, 2023; Thurman et al., 2019) or highlighting tensions that arise in adoption discourses between technological promises, professional norms, and economic pressures (e.g., D'haeseleer et al., 2025; Moran & Shaikh, 2022). While these studies offer valuable insights into use and adoption, our contribution is to show how the affordances of GenAI reconfigure the broader conditions under which media organizations operate. In doing so, we add three elements to the debate.

First, we extend prior accounts by showing that GenAI not only introduces new use cases but also reconfigures the broader conditions under which media organizations operate, through new gatekeeping mechanisms, multi-level dependencies, and a redefinition of the media value chain. Second, we shift the analytical focus from fragmented adoption stories to a systemic perspective that demonstrates how provision, generation, and interaction are

interconnected through recursive loops. Third, we broaden the scope of existing discussions by linking producer- and user-side dynamics: whereas some studies have looked narrowly at how consumers attribute value to AI-generated content (Graefe & Bohlken, 2020; Rix et al., 2025), we highlight how these dynamics are inseparable from transformations on the producer side, where publishers must adapt their role within AI-driven ecosystems. Our findings indicate that the growing pervasiveness and improving quality of commercial GenAI tools may contribute to a renewed shift in evaluative standards, as AI-generated outputs become an increasingly normalized part of everyday news consumption.

Practical contribution

For practitioners, our findings offer important strategic implications. Media companies may need to reposition themselves within the AI-driven content ecosystem, reassessing both their technological dependencies and their editorial strategies. As our cross-case study shows, lower-quality or highly standardized content producers are especially at risk of being replaced or marginalized by GenAI systems. As with previous disruptions, publishers can choose between cooperation and circumvention: either aligning closely with dominant AI providers or seeking alternative content delivery and monetization models. Crucially, our study highlights that many publishers may underestimate the gatekeeping power embedded in tools they adopt for efficiency reasons. By understanding these hidden dynamics, media companies can make more informed choices about where and how they integrate AI into their workflows. This includes reevaluating which phases of content production should be automated and to what extent.

Beyond the organizational level, our study points to critical regulatory implications. Major digital platforms are no longer just intermediaries; they are becoming providers of foundational AI models themselves. This vertical integration deepens their structural control over both the production and distribution of information. Policymakers must address this growing concentration of infrastructural power by developing frameworks that safeguard plurality, prevent monopolization of generative infrastructures, and ensure that key informational technologies remain accessible and accountable to the broader public.

Our study carries broader societal implications. News publishers play a critical role in supporting democratic societies by providing trusted, verifiable information. The evolving dynamics of GenAI threaten to obscure the origins behind that information. As the boundaries between publisher content and system-generated summaries become less visible, so too does the public's ability to evaluate the credibility and source of the content they consume. Our findings call for greater societal awareness of how information consumption

practices shape industry dynamics, and, in turn, the reliability of public knowledge.

Limitations and future research

As with all studies, ours has limitations that open up opportunities for future research. First, we focus primarily on the perspective of traditional media companies without incorporating the viewpoints of intermediaries or AI providers. Yet, the dynamics we describe are reciprocal and would benefit from a multi-sided exploration. Future studies could include platforms and technology firms to build a more comprehensive understanding of the GenAI ecosystem. Second, our study is based on European media companies, which may limit generalizability due to cultural, regulatory, or market-specific factors. However, we selected a diverse set of media organizations whose structural roles are representative of global industry types. Third, our findings are based on the assumption that publishers use GenAI tools provided by platform intermediaries, a condition that currently holds for most widespread use cases. However, as alternative AI models gain traction, future research could explore how these dynamics change when media companies adopt non-platform-owned AI models or when they develop in-house solutions.

To conclude, this study highlights how GenAI is not merely a productivity tool; it is a structuring force in the media ecosystem, introducing new forms of gatekeeping that alter workflows, power relations, and strategic positioning. By revealing how these dynamics unfold across the media value chain, we provide a foundation for future research on AI's role in shaping media production, distribution, and editorial control.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Data availability statement

The participants of this study did not give written consent for their data to be shared publicly, so due to the sensitive nature of the research supporting data is not available.

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Appendix

Detailed within-case analysis

PublishCo A is a fully digital mainstream publisher within a diversified media group, targeting broad national audiences with news, service, and entertainment content. Its business model is primarily advertising-based, making it highly dependent on visibility via digital intermediaries. The company adopts a proactive stance toward GenAI. Press releases reveal that the publishing house was among the first to experiment with GenAI on a large scale, even to completely automate the content development and curation for magazines. These experiences led to the learning that editorial oversight remains indispensable: *“We don’t publish any article without someone reviewing it”* (A1). PublishCoA aims to reduce external dependencies by developing as much in-house as possible: *“We prefer to develop all possible applications ourselves rather than being dependent on [...] for example Meta”* (A2). At the same time, it acknowledges the increasing power imbalances, especially when it comes to training foundation models: *“Microsoft simply has unlimited money and unlimited computing power”* (A3). GenAI is widely used for drafting, reformatting, and automating content: *“These [publishing] quotas can now only be met with the help of AI”* (A2). PublishCoA is especially concerned about declining visibility due to recipient-facing GenAI in search engines: *“I think we’re screwed”* (A2).

PublishCo B is a premium digital publisher embedded in a legacy media brand known for high-quality journalism. Its offerings include in-depth reporting, investigative journalism, and commentary targeted at an intellectual and professional readership. Its business model relies significantly on direct revenues through paid content. This positioning allows PublishCoB a degree of editorial independence from platform dynamics but also compels it to maintain high content standards to justify its value proposition. In terms of GenAI, PublishCoB adopts a cautious yet exploratory stance. The organization permits selective experimentation with GenAI tools. An editor shares: *“You can’t create high-quality content with GenAI, but you can create okay-ish content in large quantities”* (B3). GenAI is used primarily to support tasks such as brainstorming headlines, generating teasers, and providing inspiration for article structures: *“[We tried it] to see how it could help with one of our least favorite tasks, which is finding titles and teasers”* (B2). PublishCoB is highly concerned about the reuse of proprietary content to train large models and generate platform-native summaries that bypass the publisher’s site. As an editor notes: *“[Digital intermediaries] use our content to generate their answers, but we don’t see any money from it”* (B3). This concern extends beyond copyright to fundamental questions of visibility and value erosion. The managing director warns: *“Ever since these results started being shown directly in the search, nobody clicks on the underlying websites anymore”* (B1). In this regard, GenAI is perceived as an economic threat to organic traffic and subscription pathways. *“GenAI worries us, because the major traffic provider, which brings people to our site, [...] is Google”* (B1), says the innovation lead. In response, PublishCoB evaluates strategic responses such as stricter access control.

PublishCo C operates as a mainstream publisher with a regional and national focus, offering both print and digital news formats. Its core products include daily and weekly newspapers as well as an online portal. The outlet is part of a bigger publishing group. Revenue is generated through a mix of subscriptions and advertising. Despite ongoing digitalization, the publisher remains closely tied to its historical role as a print-based regional newspaper and retains a legacy structure. Its stance toward GenAI is marked by cautious skepticism. It is currently used to support summarizing articles or adapting formats. Editors emphasize the unreliability of GenAI-generated outputs, even when using proprietary data: *“It still doesn’t mean that [the output] is correct”* (C3). GenAI is perceived as a tool for coping with resource scarcity, shrinking margins, and growing competition. Moreover, the organization expresses concern

over the loss of visibility and control when content is scraped or summarized by intermediaries: *“It may leave out things that are relevant”* (C3). The product manager acknowledges that regional specificity may offer some protection: *“Regional content can only be partially captured by Google or AI,”* though *“they can crawl the whole internet, it doesn’t matter”* (C1). PublishCoC does recognize the technological potential of GenAI for selected content types, particularly agency-based or low-stakes information. However, its overall posture remains that of a “traditional” newsroom prioritizing professional judgment.

PublishCo D is a digital magazine embedded within a larger media group and positioned as a mainstream and commercially driven content provider with a broad, national reach. Its editorial strategy is geared toward accessible news and lifestyle-oriented journalism, including entertainment and culture formats. Its business model is predominantly advertising-driven, relying heavily on traffic volumes and content scalability. The organization shows a pragmatic and productivity-oriented stance toward GenAI. It embraces the technology primarily to reduce workload. The editor-in-chief outlines this rationale: *“One of the big questions is [. . .] how we can make the work of our editors easier?”* noting that GenAI *“can assist you with standard processes”* (D1). Accordingly, GenAI is used to automate components of the editorial workflow, including the production of (utility) articles, the adaptation of content for different channels, and the enhancement of visual content. Despite this functional integration, PublishCoD is alert due to the competitive challenges that accompany widespread GenAI deployment. One editor warns of market saturation and content oversupply: *“It is dangerous for us [. . .] because the internet is now flooded with content”* (D2). This concern is also linked to the erosion of content differentiation and the declining visibility of publisher brands on platform ecosystems. In this context, the organization perceives a dual imperative: to integrate AI for reasons of speed and efficiency, and simultaneously to invest in content quality in order to stand out. The editor-in-chief notes the *“need to differentiate”* from low-quality, mass-produced content (D1).

PublishCo E is an internationally oriented premium digital magazine, widely recognized for its data-driven journalism, analytical depth, and professional tone. Its content portfolio targets a global readership and covers economics, politics, and global affairs. The publisher operates with a strong direct-to-consumer model, generating a significant portion of its revenue through subscriptions and paid content. PublishCoE’s approach to GenAI is marked by strategic selectivity and a strong emphasis on human editorial authority. Rather than pursuing full automation or high-volume content expansion, the organization explores the technology as a tool for augmenting analytical tasks. Editors and journalists use the technology to support data interpretation, summarize complex information, or generate early drafts for structured content. A data journalist acknowledges the cognitive influence of such outputs: *“When you say, ‘Hey, can you interpret this dataset for me?’ and when you read it for the first time, I believe it does influence you [. . .]. It always sticks, whether from a person or from an AI”* (E2). PublishCoE maintains strict internal guidelines regarding AI use: *“Our leadership team [. . .] requires us to be extremely careful with the data that we’re using for AI”* (E3). This illustrates the effort to strike a balance between openness to technological innovation and the protection of proprietary content and editorial standards. The publisher is also engaged in strategic partnerships, including with AI-focused startups and search engine providers, allowing for experimentation under controlled conditions. These collaborations are not solely defensive but are seen as a way to embed editorial values into future models. As one executive puts it, *“It’s the solution for content companies when it comes only to one specific revenue stream. And this revenue stream is training data for the AI models”* (E3). While not dependent on platform traffic to the same extent as other mainstream publishers, PublishCoE is concerned about whether content is reused without compensation or attribution. Its preference is to engage on its own terms and shape how it is presented in AI-driven environments.

PublishCo F is a national digital news outlet positioned at the intersection of general-interest journalism and multimedia service content. As part of a larger media group, the organization targets a broad audience with a high-frequency publishing strategy that spans politics, economy, culture, and lifestyle. The publisher operates under a reach-oriented, advertising-driven model that demands continuous output and platform optimization. As a result, editorial workflows are geared toward scale. GenAI plays a central role in this infrastructure: *“It’s no longer just a smart screwdriver, but rather a copilot, an assistant, a colleague”* (F1). AI is used to automate repetitive tasks, generate article drafts, adapt text lengths, and repurpose content. The AI lead explains how work is shared among humans and AI: *“Editors should invest more effort into creativity and research, and eventually, the AI will largely handle the rest”* (F3). PublishCoF is also engaged in strategic partnerships with technology companies. Recognizing that intermediaries require a steady supply of content to train AI models, the publisher leverages its high output volume as a bargaining chip. As one executive explains: *“These large language models are making contracts with word factories because we produce millions of words every day; otherwise, the models won’t learn”* (F1). These partnerships are not merely transactional but are framed as a way to influence the epistemic foundations of future AI systems: *“If we are the ones training the models, our value system is embedded in the models of tomorrow”* (F1). PublishCoF aims to integrate conversational search interfaces into its own offerings. This *“conscious cannibalization”* is a preemptive move to retain users in-house before they turn to external AI tools (F3).

PublishCo G is a nationally renowned premium news organization with a strong reputation for investigative journalism. The publisher addresses a discerning, politically engaged readership and is primarily financed through subscriptions. Although PublishCo G remains cautious in integrating GenAI into editorial workflows, it engages with the technology in a proactive and informed way. Dedicated AI roles have been established to monitor developments, assess capabilities, and ensure a deep understanding of the technology’s potential and limitations. This internal expertise enables strategic experimentation, always within clear editorial boundaries. GenAI is used selectively for supportive tasks such as error detection. As one editor describes: it *“can serve as a kind of safety net to prevent small mistakes from slipping through”* (G3). The publisher emphasizes that editorial decisions must remain under human control and expresses significant concern about the reuse and repurposing of its content by digital intermediaries. The perceived loss of attribution and economic value is a recurring theme in the interviews. One fact-checker questions the fundamental value of original reporting: *“What value does it have if things I carefully write down are now just scraped from the web?”* (G2). Similarly, one executive warns about the consequences of zero-click searches: *“While sources are listed, for the average user, [the AI summaries] are usually enough”* (G1). At the same time, the organization monitors changing patterns in user behavior. As an AI project manager observes: *“Google is now summarizing direct answers [...], now, you just ask your AI assistant or quickly Google it, and soon, both might be the same thing”* (G3). Rather than reacting defensively, PublishCoG evaluates strategic responses, including selective partnerships and prototype development with external partners. In sum, PublishCoG combines critical distance with a high degree of technological openness.